Chapter 29

Triumph and Tragedy:
Forty-one Long Days at Chandigarh

THE ONE CITY THAT KIRAN REALLY LOVED WAS CHANDIGARH. SHE knew this place thoroughly, virtually inch by inch, thanks to her numerous cycling trips when she was a post-graduate student there. As she recalls: 'Every time it rained, I would pick up my bicycle, and go cycling in Chandigarh. One way the wind would be favourable but I had to struggle the other way. I enjoyed it then. It built my stamina for tennis championships.'

The position of the police chief at Chandigarh was due, in fact, overdue, for a change. Kiran requested for a posting to that city. She got it. She had put in ten months as joint commissioner (training) at the Police Training College at New Delhi. In her farewell address to the trainees there, she said that she was going to Chandigarh to face a new challenge and test herself on how she would perform as the head of a police force. She also wanted to ascertain for herself as to how she would lead the force and provide the professionalism that was expected from the police services. Further, she wanted to find out as to how she would deal with the pressures that come with that leadership and whether or not she would herself live up to her own convictions.

These observations were indeed prophetic!

Kiran was tested many times over on all these counts in just 41 (5 April 1999 to 15 May 1999) days she spent as inspector general of police, Chandigarh, the shortest posting of her career but the most eventful and the most traumatic.

Kiran's colleagues recall her first two weeks in office:

> The collapsed systems of policing became functional. All diverted manpower towards personal staffing in the garb of keeping security came back. Mrs Bedi herself returned her escort vehicle and the staff. Traffic Police cleaned up its act and became visible. The traffic cranes were back on the roads. Drivers became alert, and went looking for parking lots. Pollution check centres had long queues. Cyclists went into the cycle lanes. Youngsters driving two-wheelers [usually recklessly] abandoned their vehicles out of fear of getting caught. Markets appeared orderly, for the shopkeepers and vendors vacated the footpaths on which they had displayed their goods for the use of pedestrians for whom they were meant. Police stations got their diverted men back. Hundreds of home guards were recalled to duty. Vacancies in the Home Guard Department were ordered to be filled up. Women police were sent back to police stations from invisible backyards, where they were resting and rusting. Police Control Room staff returned the calls to check if they had been attended to. The staff earlier on twelve-hour shift now did eight-hourly duty. Absenteeism was now a thing of the past.
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> The IGP herself [could turn up at] any police station at 9 a.m. sharp. Hence all of us were …